

The 4 Levels of Automation

Where you are right now changes what you should build next. This is the map.

Why this matters **right now**

- **Professionals are being replaced — not by AI, but by people using AI.** Companies figured out one person with the right automations can do the work of three. Layoffs are happening not because the role disappeared, but because it got smaller.
- **Businesses using advanced automation are pulling far ahead.** More output, faster turnaround, lower overhead — same team. The ones not doing this aren't standing still. They're losing ground every month.
- **The tools are now free and accessible to anyone.** Two years ago you needed a developer and a budget. Today you can build multi-step automations with no code, for free, in an afternoon. The barrier is gone. The gap is now a choice.
- **This is not a trend — it's the new baseline.** Like having a website in 2005. The only question is whether you're early or late — and right now, most people are still late.

Why this is **relevant for you**

- **You don't need to be technical.** I studied IT years ago and never used it. I work in sales. I built all of this from scratch by watching tutorials and experimenting.
- **If you do repetitive work, you can automate it.** Follow-ups, quotes, reports, data entry, scheduling — anything you do the same way every time is a candidate.
- **You don't need to automate everything at once.** Pick the one task that eats the most time. Build that. Get it working. Stack from there.
- **Time saved compounds.** One hour building an automation saves you an hour every single week — forever. The earlier you start, the bigger the advantage over those who wait.

LEVELS 1 & 2 — THE FOUNDATION

LEVEL 1

Basic Triggers



Zapier



IFTTT IFTTT



Make

One thing happens — one other thing happens automatically. Nothing thinks, nothing decides. It just runs the action every single time.

THINK OF IT LIKE...

An alarm clock. You set it once. Every morning at 7am it goes off — whether you're awake or not. One trigger, one result, zero decisions involved.

REAL EXAMPLE

Someone fills out your contact form → You instantly get a notification with their details

WHAT YOU GAIN

You stop manually checking things. The system tells you. You go from reactive to informed without lifting a finger.

Build time: ~20 minutes · No coding required

LEVEL 2

Multi-Step Workflows



Make



n8n

A chain of steps that runs itself — and takes different paths depending on what it finds. Multiple actions from a single trigger, end to end.

THINK OF IT LIKE...

A checklist that completes itself. Step 1 finishes, Step 2 automatically starts. It can even branch — "if this is true, do that. If not, do this instead." No human needed to move it forward.

REAL EXAMPLE

New lead submits a form → System checks CRM → If not there, creates the record → Sends welcome message → Flags for follow-up in 3 days

WHAT YOU GAIN

Entire processes run end-to-end without you. The system doesn't just notify you — it handles the next 5 steps on your behalf.

Build time: Hours to days · More complex, still no code

LEVELS 3 & 4 — WHERE REAL LEVERAGE STARTS

LEVEL 3

AI-Enhanced Automation

 n8n + AI  Make + AI

Same preset steps every time — but one of those steps uses AI to write, summarise, classify, or decide something intelligent on your behalf.

THINK OF IT LIKE...

Autocomplete on your phone, but built into your workflow. The steps are the same every time. But instead of sending a generic template, AI reads the context and writes a smart, personalised output for that specific person or situation.

REAL EXAMPLE

New lead submits a form → AI reads their details, industry, and role → Writes a personalised first message in your voice → Automatically sends it to them

WHAT YOU GAIN

Your automations go from generic to intelligent. Same volume of leads, same speed — but with personalisation that used to take a human 20 minutes each.

Build time: **Days** · Same structure, smarter output

LEVEL 4

Agentic Workflows

 Claude Code

No preset steps. AI is the brain — it reads the situation, decides what to do next, does it, checks its own work, then hands the finished output to you for approval.

THINK OF IT LIKE...

Telling a capable employee what result you want — not how to do it. You say "build a proposal for this client." They figure out the steps, do the research, write the document, review it, then come back and say "ready to send?"

REAL EXAMPLE

Client details arrive → AI reads their history and scope → Builds tailored proposal → Reviews its own output → Drafts personalised email → Waits for your one-click approval

WHAT YOU GAIN

An entire role's worth of admin runs on its own. Work that used to take 45 minutes per client becomes a 2-minute review and a click. This is where real leverage lives.

Build time: **Weeks to get right** · Highest leverage of any level

THE FORMULA — HOW TO FIND YOUR FIRST AUTOMATION

01

Most Time

What single task eats the most hours in your week? Specifically. For me it was writing proposals — 30 to 45 minutes. Every. Single. One.

+

02

Repetitive

Do you do the same steps every time? If yes, a machine can do those steps too. Repetition is the signal. Variation is the noise.

+

03

Clear Trigger

Is there a clear "when this happens, the task starts"? New lead. Call ends. Client replies. If there's a clear start point, you can build a trigger.

All three = your first automation. Don't start with the biggest problem. Like renovating a house — you don't gut the whole building. Fix the one room costing you the most. Build that, get it working, then stack.

MY PROGRESSION — SALES MANAGER, NOT A DEVELOPER

- L1

Started here. Basic triggers on Zapier.

New lead fills a form → I get a notification. 20 minutes to build. Changed how I thought about work.
- L2

Moved to n8n. Multi-step flows.

Lead → CRM → auto follow-up sequence. Broke it a few times. Once it worked, it ran without me.
- L3

Added an AI node to an existing flow.

Same structure. But now AI writes personalised messages instead of generic templates.
- L4

Today — agentic proposal system.

Client details come in. Claude reads them, builds the proposal, checks it, drafts the email. I click send.

Proposals: **30–45 min → under 5 min**. Follow-ups go out same day, automatically. CRM updates itself after every call. Every morning I get a briefing — tells me exactly what to work on. Best month: **\$114K in new work**. AI handled the admin. I focused on the calls.

WHERE TO START BASED ON YOUR LEVEL

- Never automated anything?

Start with n8n. It's free and open source.

Connect two apps you already use. One trigger, one action. Just get the feeling of something running without you. That first moment is what hooks you.
- Already using n8n or Make?

Add a Claude AI node to an existing flow. That's all it takes to go from Level 2 → Level 3. Your automation goes from moving data to making intelligent decisions with it.
- Ready to go agentic?

Start with Claude Code. Write what you want in plain English — not code. Build the first version. Test it on a real case. Improve from there. No engineering background needed.
- The rule

Most time + repetitive + clear trigger = **your first build**. Don't try to automate everything. Pick the one task. Get it working. Then the next. You'll naturally move up the levels.

QUICK REFERENCE — ALL 4 LEVELS AT A GLANCE

LEVEL	WHAT THINKS	BEST TOOL	CODE?	EFFORT	BEST FOR
L1 — Basic	Nothing. Rules only.	Zapier, IFTTT	No	20 min	Notifications, simple connections
L2 — Workflow	Rules + conditions.	n8n, Make	No	Hours–days	Multi-step processes, CRM, follow-ups
L3 — AI-Enhanced	AI writes/decides one step.	n8n + Claude node	Minimal	Days	Personalised outreach, summaries, triage
L4 — Agentic	AI plans + executes everything.	Claude Code	Plain English	Weeks	Proposals, complex reasoning, full workflows

More breakdowns like this every week on Instagram.

@allenenriquezz

Follow for more levels, tools, real examples — and what's actually working right now.